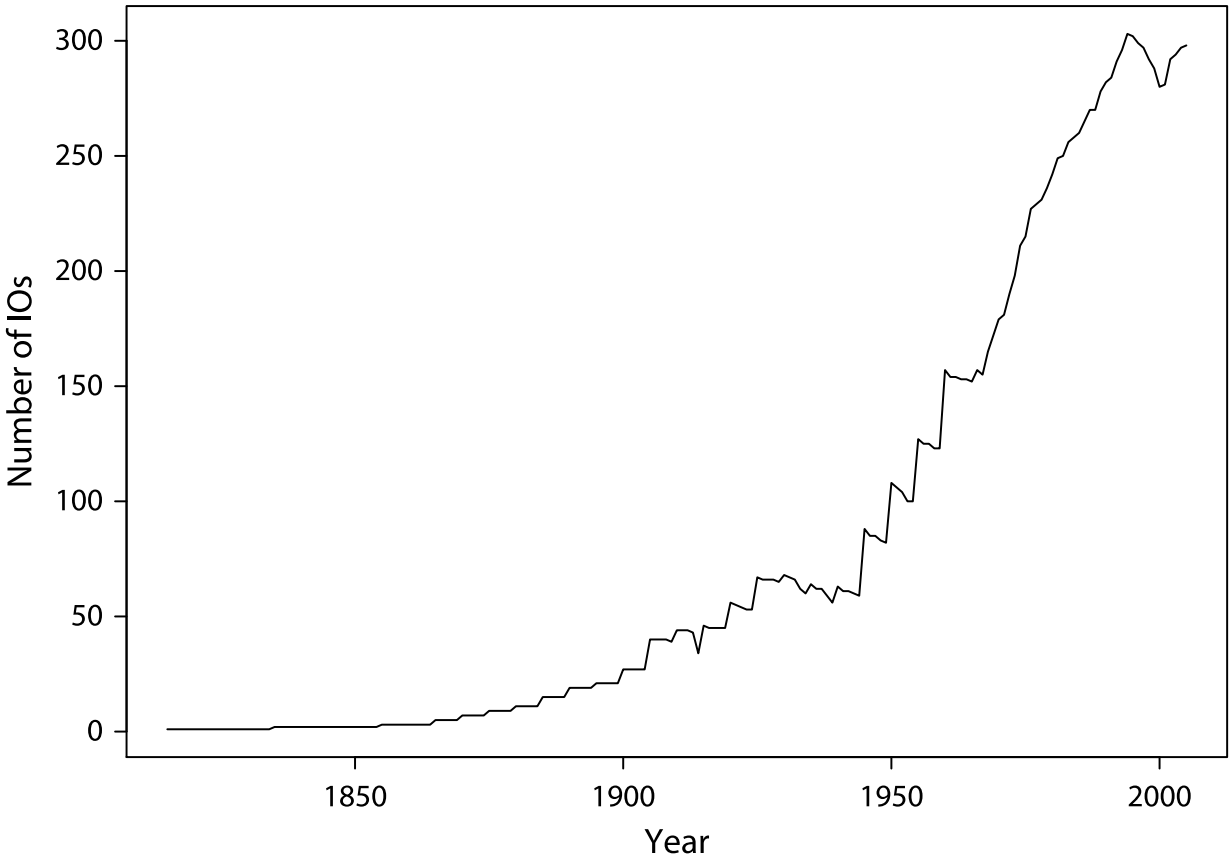


FIGURE 3.1. Number of IOs active over time. Data from (Pevehouse, Nordstrom, and Warnke 2004).

The increased complexity and authority of IOs have provoked widespread criticism, particularly from populist leaders who view them as intrusive and elitist. These leaders argue that IOs undermine state sovereignty, operate with democratic deficits, and prioritize elite-driven agendas over national interests. The populist resurgence is deeply tied to globalization—a catch-all term to describe the increased economic interconnectedness of the post–Cold War era—and to the perceived "denationalization" of political rule as global governance has grown more technocratic and detached from everyday citizens.

Indeed, many populists have found IOs to be easy targets for their anti-elite narratives. As bureaucratic entities staffed by highly educated international elites, IOs epitomize the foreign control populists rally against. Their mission to constrain state behavior, whether through trade rules,